

employees' market.

"Employees today are married to their skills and not the job," Deepti Sagar, Chief People and Experience Officer at Deloitte India, says of the post-pandemic workforce. Roopank Chaudhary, Partner & Chief Commercial Officer, HCM (India and South Asia) at Aon, says the tech sector itself is seeing a slowdown, but tech talent remains in high demand in other sectors. "A bright Indian economy means traditional non-tech sectors are brimming with opportunities," he says, adding that global economy-dependent sectors such as IT/ITeS/start-ups are facing headwinds, while domestic economy-driven sectors such as financial services, FMCG and hospitality are doing well. Data from jobs portal Naukri seems to support this trend: Indian hiring activity saw a low 4 per cent rise in December 2022 compared to December 2021, simply because the slowdown in IT & BPO hiring was offset by growth in domestic economy-driven sectors. "The latter are poised to give out higher hikes in 2023 than they did in 2021 and 2022, while the global sectors are projecting a reduction in increments this year," adds Chaudhary. However, in the era of digitalisation, IT/tech isn't going to lie low for long. "Tech demand may bounce back in a few quarters, as experts have pointed out, and it will trigger rampant attrition again," he adds. HCL Tech's former CEO Vineet Nayar couldn't agree more: "In the medium term, the IT sector is headed only one way—up and up."

As organisations hone their hiring strategies, HR heads have an eye out for a significant change in employee mindset. With boom-and-bust cycles becoming shorter, upskilling, clear career paths and flexibility are beginning to rank higher and higher on employees' requirements. If these are not on the

table, the young employee is happy to head out the door ever so often.

LET'S LOOK AT tech. Mass layoffs have rocked IT, Big Tech and start-up firms since 2022 when worrying signs of a global slowdown started showing. Aspirational employers—including Top 25 rankers of the *BT-Taggd* Best Companies to Work For in India such as Google, Amazon and Microsoft, along with Meta, among others—have fired more than 318,000 employees the world over since early 2022. At least 45,000 people have

to capture growth opportunities, and that hiring in India continues across niche skills, functional areas, corporate functions and other roles based on business needs.

After hiring freshers in droves in 2021 to cater to unprecedented digitisation demand, IT firms are not sparing them now. In January, Wipro confirmed that it fired 452 freshers. "We expect every entry-level employee to have a certain level of proficiency in their designated area of work... Systematic and comprehensive performance evaluation process triggers a series of actions such as mentoring and

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also lost their jobs in India, mostly in the tech-driven start-up space. Recently, Accenture, No. 2 in *BT's* Best Companies listing, announced plans to let go of 19,000 people globally, including in India. "We optimise our business and lower costs wherever possible," says Lakshmi C., MD and Lead-HR, Accenture in India, but adds that it continues to invest in people and the business

retraining and, in some cases, separation of certain employees from the company," the firm had told *BT* in an emailed response to a query this January. "Over the past few months, there have been several instances of companies rescinding job offers, reducing salaries, laying off employees and implementing extended working hours," says Harpreet Singh Saluja, President of